Ford Motor Company

James P. Vondale, Director
Automotive Safety Office
Environmental & Safety Engineering

October 1, 2002

Mr. Kenneth N. Weinstein
Associate Administrator for Safety Assurance
National Highway Traffic Safety Administration
400 Seventh Street, S.W.
Washington, D.C. 20590

Dear Mr. Weinstein:

Re: Ford Recall No. 02S40 – 2000-2002 Model Year Ford Taurus/Mercury Sable Vehicles with Adjustable Pedals

Summary

- Ford Action – Ford is conducting a voluntary safety recall involving 2000-2002 model year Ford Taurus and Mercury Sable vehicles built between May 3, 1999 and September 14, 2001 inclusive in order to adjust the brake and accelerator pedals to a minimum of 50 mm of lateral separation. Although Ford has not established that lateral spacing is a significant factor in the reported pedal misapplications, this action addresses concerns raised by the agency in its current investigation. Ford believes that driver unfamiliarity with the adjustable pedal feature, and not lateral spacing, is a likely explanation for some of the reports under investigation.

- Number of Vehicles Involved – Approximately 424,164 vehicles (369,614 in the United States and Federal Territories, 45,706 in Canada, and 8,844 in other countries).

- Affect on Vehicle Operation – Simultaneous application of both the brake and accelerator pedals may result in an increase in engine RPM. This could result in a customer experiencing an "unintended vehicle speed increase" or a perceived "unable to stop" condition. In all cases, drivers are able to correct the condition by further applying the brake pedal or by simply lifting their feet from the pedals.

- Service Procedure – Owners will be instructed as to the proper way to set the position of the pedals and to take their vehicles to a Ford or Lincoln-Mercury dealer to have the spacing between the brake and accelerator pedals measured. If the spacing is found to be less than 50 mm, the dealer will be instructed to adjust the pedals to increase the distance between them to greater than 50 mm.

Attached is the detailed information required by the applicable portions of 49 CFR Part 573 – Defect and Non-Compliance Information Report.

Sincerely,

James P. Vondale

Attachment
02S40 5d/wsc/word

ATTACHMENT

49 CFR Part 573 – DEFECT INFORMATION REPORT
02S40 – 2000-2002 MODEL YEAR FORD TAURUS/MERCURY SABLE VEHICLES WITH ADJUSTABLE PEDALS

Pursuant to Part 573 of Title 49 of the Code of Federal Regulations, Defect and Noncompliance Reports, Ford Motor Company submits the following information concerning a safety recall action that it is voluntarily initiating.

573.5 (c) (2) – Potentially Affected Vehicles

2000-2002 model year Ford Taurus/Mercury Sable vehicles with adjustable pedals built between May 3, 1999 and September 14, 2001 inclusive at the Atlanta and Chicago assembly plants are potentially affected.

Because these vehicles are not produced in VIN order, information as to the applicability of this action to specific vehicles can best be obtained by either calling Ford's toll-free line (1-800-392-3673) or by contacting a local Ford dealer who can obtain specific information regarding the vehicles from the Ford On-line Automotive Service Information System (OASIS) database.

573.5 (c) (3) – Estimated Population of Vehicles Potentially Affected

Approximately 369,614 Taurus/Sable vehicles in the United States and Federal Territories.

573.5 (c) (4) – Estimated Percentage of Affected Vehicles with the Defect Condition

Based upon a survey of 821 vehicles, it is estimated that approximately 10% (36,961) of the vehicles built with adjustable pedals may exhibit pedal spacing less than or equal to 50 mm.

573.5 (c) (5) – Description of the Defect

While Ford does not believe that any defect exists, the manufacturing process of the subject Taurus/Sable adjustable pedal assembly resulted in variability in lateral pedal spacing ranging from 41 mm to 85 mm based on survey results shared with the agency. Further, our discussions with drivers of vehicles with adjustable pedals disclosed that some were unfamiliar with the feature.

There have been 18 reported accidents, and two reports of injuries attributed to this condition.

573.5 (c) (6) – Chronology of Events

On May 3, 1999 Ford began building saleable Taurus/Sable vehicles with adjustable brake and accelerator pedals.

On September 4, 2001 manufacturing processes were revised to decrease the amount of variability in lateral pedal spacing between the brake and accelerator pedals.

On May 2, 2002 NHTSA opened a defect investigation alleging unintended speed increase and/or failure to stop due to pedal spacing and/or simultaneous application of the brake and accelerator pedals in the subject vehicles. In response, a field survey of 821 Taurus/Sable vehicles was conducted in June 2002 to determine the spacing between the brake and accelerator pedals. Based on this survey, approximately 10% of the subject vehicles included in this recall may exhibit lateral pedal spacing of 50 mm or less.

573.5 (c) (8) – Service Program

Owners will be instructed as to the proper way to set the position of the pedals and to take their vehicles to a Ford or Lincoln-Mercury dealer to have the spacing between the brake and accelerator pedal measured. If the spacing is found to be less than 50 mm, the dealer will be instructed to adjust the pedals to increase the distance between them to greater than 50 mm.

There will be no charge to owners for this inspection and service.

573.5 (c) (9) – Press statement and Dealer/Owner Letters

Ford does plan to make a formal public statement concerning the subject matter of this action. It is estimated that dealer and owner Notification letters will be sent out the week of November 4, 2002. A copy of the Notification letters to dealers and owners from Ford will be forwarded when available.

573.5 (c) (11) – Recall Number

Ford has assigned recall number 02S40 to this action.